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Kristen Korb

Bassist and vocalist Kristen Korb is becoming a well known artist in the west coast jazz scene. She makes her home in San Diego and often performs with flutist Holly Hofmann. Her debut album featured the Ray Brown Trio.

Kristen was interviewed in Scottsdale, Arizona on April 16, 2000, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Scottsdale, Arizona filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm quite pleased to have a young, up-and-coming jazz star, Kristen Korb, bassist, and you made quite an impression here at the festival so far.

KK: Oh, thank you.

MR: I'm kind of at a disadvantage because I don't know a lot about you.

KK: Most people don't.

MR: Well that's why we're here. Tell me where you were born and when.

KK: Well I was born and raised in Montana, the jazz mecca of the west. And actually my family had moved to Boise, Idaho where my father had a western wear store. And that was like through my kindergarten and junior high years. And when I was in sixth grade the junior high choir and band programs came through the schools and I was sitting on the gym floor with all the other kids and I heard the choir sing "Save the Bones for Henry Jones/'Cause Henry Don't Eat No Meat," and I don't know why but it just knocked me out. I was just like oh this is the coolest thing. Because up until that point all I knew was country & western music. I thought was going to be Barbara Mandrell. I loved playing guitar, I did Anne Murray songs, and we did a little bluegrass in the family, my younger brothers played and so we all kind of would play that stuff. But when I got into junior high I wanted to play for that vocal jazz group. And the choir director said well it's a bass guitar, but if you want to come in on your lunch hours or before school or after school, you're more than welcome to play the instrument and see what you think. Well it didn't take very long for me to get into that. And he encouraged me to go to a jazz camp that summer after my seventh grade year. Except for it was a high school camp. He said, "You know this is very serious. If you're going to go to this camp, you've got to practice. Because if they find out you are in seventh grade, they're going to ship you home faster than anything." So they had to start pulling me out of the practice rooms at this camp because I was so afraid that they were going to send me home, that I wouldn't be good enough, that I was just practicing everything. So I did my first vocal solo there, "I've Got

a Crush on You," and I was so scared, it was [sings]. But the camp was so cool because it was like this big, warm fuzzy hug-fest at the camp. So just the fact that you were up there, and everybody is just smiling at you and being so supportive. And by the time I got done with the song it was like wheew, wow, this is cooool. So I went to camp again the next year, and when I got in the ninth grade our family moved back to Montana. And I thought my jazz career was over because I mean I went back to the sticks again.

MR: Well there's more jazz in Idaho than there is in Montana?

KK: Well at least I thought there was. I mean I think it's all over but it's just where you look. And I think as long as you're open to it and receptive to it, it will find you. And it was one of those things that even though I was living in Boise, Idaho at the time when Gene Harris was there, because of my age and the society there, it was not cool for a seventh or an eighth grader to go to the local bar to go hear jazz musicians. So I never actually got to know who Gene Harris was until after I'd moved away. But when I got to Montana, in high school and everything, I ran into people — oh you like jazz, oh, here listen to this, here, check this out. And so making tapes for friends and going back and forth, and my brothers got into the music so they started signing up for every record club, Columbia House and BMG Jazz Club, and played drop the needle tests with me at three o'clock in the morning, and come jumping into my bed. And it was one of those things that even though Montana was not the place necessarily for jazz, I did find it, and people that love the music, and that were encouraging. And then when I was in college I went to Eastern Montana College in Billings. And I started my own groups, played in the jazz band, and we had a jazz festival that I became student director of, and we had like Maynard Ferguson and George Shearing came and we had some people from California come in, some professors, John Prince, guitarist Tom Bevan came in, Bobby Shew was there. And so through meeting these people and just hanging out with everybody that I could, Emily Remler, the great guitar player, came through Billings about four months before she died, so I got to hang with her a little bit. She said some really important things. She said get lessons from whoever you can. When you go to a town, you study with the people that are there. If somebody comes to your town, you get a lesson with them. It doesn't have to be anything more than a lesson but you need to hang with these people if this is what you want to do. So I got my bachelor's in Music Ed, moved down to San Diego to study bass with Bert Turetzky at UCSD, and then Ray Brown came through San Diego. And the first year I was just like oh it's Ray Brown, oh I want a lesson, I want a lesson. And I went up to him and shook his hand and I'm like, "Oh Mr. Brown, I really enjoyed your performance," and he was in one of those moods, you know he was kind of like the king welcoming the court at the end of the gig. And he didn't say anything, not hello, good

evening, nothing. He just felt my calluses. And I've never had anybody feel my callus before. And I'm like what is this? And it was like, "You need to practice more."

MR: Is that right?

KK: And I just was like, ohhh, thank you. And I had him sign my CD that I bought. So I went home—

MR: That was your lesson.

KK: That was my lesson. It was a very good lesson. Because I went home and I practiced for the next year. Because I had found out that he came through San Diego about once a year. And so what I did is I worked on things and I read and found out that he liked to play golf and so by the time he came back around again, I had scheduled a concert of my own for the week after he was there, and I wanted to be sure I had stuff ready to go. And at that point, because I didn't sing and play at the same time until after I got into grad school where my bass teacher said, "Well you sing and you play, why don't you do both at the same time?" I was like okay. So I tried it. So at that point I had a year under my belt of working on that, and then hooked up with him at his concert again, and introduced myself like we had never met before. And he didn't remember the year before so that was cool. And I actually got the lesson with him. And during the lesson we had talked. I said this is what I want to do. I love my bass, not as much as you do, but I love my bass. I want to record, I want to tour, I want to do the things that you're doing. And at that point in my life it was I don't know if I'm good enough. I realize I'm from Montana. I realize that my scope, my view of where I stand is very skewed. I don't know, am I good enough to do this. Because to be a jazz person from Montana, it's not exactly a likely scenario. And so I had a lot of doubts.

MR: You were very self directed from an early age though.

KK: A little driven.

MR: A little driven. Okay.

KK: Well it's just one of those things — my mother and father have always been really supportive about setting goals. You see something that you want, and you take the steps that it takes to get there. And it means practicing, it means self-sacrifice, it means you do the stuff that needs to be done. And for me to go in and get the lesson with Ray, that's all I really wanted. And I wanted to get some kind of affirmations, you know, if I am good enough to go and do these things, who do I need to talk to? Because I want to get hoppin' on it.

MR: Up until that point, what was your bass instruction as far as conceiving of bass lines and all that kind of thing?

KK: Well the camp that I went to started me a little bit on here's your scales, here's some forms to use, a lot of listening, like to Ray and Paul Chambers and Mingus and Oscar

Pettiford and Leroy Vinnegar, and George Duvivier, Major Holly, Slam Stewart, listening to everything that I could get my hands on. I mean that was most of it. I really didn't get any formal bass lessons until I came down to UCSD for my master's degree. Up until that point it had really been kind of [inaudible]. I'd listening a lot, I loved the music, I sang more than played actually when I was in Montana. I mean I played, because I was the only bass player around. But as far as really knowing the right technique and pulling into the instrument and really getting a sound, I had no concept beyond what I was hearing, and trying to make a good sound. But if you don't have the technique you can't be efficient with it. So when I studied with Bert he put me through the classical paces, I did the Simandl Etude book, I did a lot of bowing. My master's recital was half classical and half jazz. And because UCSD is a real avant garde school, I got to study some with the trombonist George Lewis, I did a piece called "B.B. Wolf," it stands for the big bad wolf, and it's a piece composed for speaker and bass. And usually it's two separate people. And it has like a tango section where you're doing all these alternate techniques, and I'm the big bad wolf but I'm really not so bad, the wolf get a bad rap. It goes through a tango section and a blues section, and wolf calls, and you're hitting the bass all over, and crazy things. So Bert really put me through the paces. And he's one of the finest teachers I've ever studied with in that he saw where I was at, he saw the talent that was within me, but he was also very open and just said, "Okay, yeah you've got some stuff together, but you need to do this and this and this, and we're going to make hay slowly, and we're going to take you step by step to get the technique together so you can do what you need to do." Not that it had to be — for him, I didn't really do any jazz stuff for him. It was let's get your chops together. And that way you can follow your own voice and whatever that needs to be. And he's gone way back with Ray Brown so he was really encouraging and gave me a CD to give to Ray, and Bert is a master teacher and I really have learned so much from him. And I still go and get the five hundred mile check-up with him every once in a while.

MR: Did you study piano along the way, harmony, that kind of thing?

KK: Yeah, I did. As a kid I did 4-1/2 years of guitar lessons, I did about a year and a half of piano and the school choir, I was doing accompaniment things. And I took a few jazz lessons in seventh grade to try to, I wanted to improve my voicings, but I really wasn't sure what I wanted. So I did that, and then of course through getting a Music Ed degree you have to take two years of theory, and I took music history, and all that sort of stuff. But I think I've learned just as much if not more from hanging out with other musicians or trying to transcribe a tune and write out the chord changes and what I think they are and then go to a piano player I respect and have them tear it apart and say, "Okay now this is what you mean, this is what you want, this is a flatted ninth, a raised eleventh," and

I would have some other kind of harmonic thing set up. Because I can follow the bass lines pretty well, but sometimes those interior voices I wasn't as strong with. So I mean that really helped a lot. And I mean I still go to piano players all the time. And here's what I'm thinking when I want to put these changes together. Is this what I really want?" And then they would play some things and I'm like, "Oh I like that sound, what are you doing?" But I'm always learning. I mean that's the beauty of this music is that we never, ever stop. Whether it's a new tune, a new set of changes for a tune we already know, melodic ideas, approaches to a song, it's just wonderful.

MR: So after you got your education up to the point where you felt pretty confident, did you have to choose between the East Coast and the West Coast? Or did it just kind of happen for you that you ended up—

KK: Well by the time I had my master's I was already working. My goal was while I was in school I was trying to get out of school as fast as possible, musically speaking. So while I was doing my studies, because I was watching the people around me that weren't necessarily there — they weren't jazzers, it's not a jazz school. But I would see them with the avant garde thing. And they would be so intent on the performances for those school concerts and those ensembles at school that they never saw the community. They never integrated themselves. And then they would end up staying for their Ph.D.s because they didn't have anywhere else to go. And for me I wanted to use the schooling to get my chops together. And to me, taking those lessons and doing the studies that I had to do to get the degree was to get me out into the community. So the first weekend I was in town I went down to the Horton Grand Hotel, which is where the jazz stuff was happening in San Diego. So I'd go down there every weekend and hang out with the musicians and learn and listen. They used to call me "the kid." It's the kid again. So I met Holly Hofmann, who was a wonderful mentor for me there. She has been really supportive and encouraging and real honest with me when I've been playing well and when I haven't been playing well. That was a wonderful opportunity. So like by the time I got done with the degree I've just been in San Diego.

MR: There's a few other good fellas there and players in San Diego.

KK: Oh yeah, James Moody, Charles McPherson, Mundell Lowe, Barney Kessel lives there, although you know of course with the stroke he's not playing. But yeah, every once in a while he'll come to one of my gigs and hang out. It's marvelous. It's really cool.

MR: Did you get to learn the business end of things a little bit also then?

KK: Holly. Holly has been really good about that. And I've been one that I've always been pretty self-sufficient. And I know that in order to get to where I need to be I have to take care of business. Because nobody else is going to do it for me. And you really don't have anybody else to lean on. So it's been one of those things that — I've been pleased — I

mean you take your knocks along the way and you learn stuff the hard way, but at the same time I like, we have to, we just, there's no other way about it. It's like sink or swim. And if you don't take care of business it's going to bite you.

MR: So what was your first, what you consider to be a gig or a series of gigs where you really got to pull it all together, and kind of use everything you'd learned up to that point?

KK: Every gig.

MR: Every gig.

KK: Every gig. There's no one gig. I mean there's some where you play with better people than others but every gig is important. Every gig that I play and have ever played is using everything that I've been learning up to that point. Because you're always trying to make the best music that you can. Of course I mean there's like a whole series of things. When I was a kid just being able to go and sing at that jazz camp. That was huge for me. That was life changing. Playing bass in an ensemble at the college that I went to with David Garibaldi, the first time I really felt a solid groove. It was just like — uhhhh.

MR: Oh is that the fella, he's in Tower of Power?

KK: Yeah. And it was like a funk set. But it was like one of those things where I actually felt a solid groove. It was the first time I'd every played with — but it was just like oh this feels really good. You know, it's just little moments like that, I mean they keep encouraging you. Or sometimes it was not even playing at all but just being, sitting there in a room listening to Ray Brown play a walking bass line. You know don't even have him solo, just to have him walk in the medium Ray Brown groove. I mean it was just — there are a series of things that are really important like that, but I think every gig is important. It doesn't matter if it's in a restaurant, a hotel, at a jazz party like this. Every one of them demands, the music demands that you play your best and use everything that you've learned up to that point.

MR: Do you have a certain style of jazz that is your favorite?

KK: Yeah. I try to take in, there's different parts of me that, there's a side of me that's a real bebopper. Vocally I love the lyrics of Eddie Jefferson, Jon Hendricks doing — I love writing lyrics to solos. Well last night, the "East of the Sun," that was a lyric that I put to a Stan Getz solo off the Stan Getz, Kenny Barron "People Time." I love that. But at the same time there's nothing as fun as just a nice medium blues groove, and just to play and just to feel the groove and to be able to support others. Sometimes it's just fun to play some avant garde stuff and just to be weird and explore sounds and textures. But I think probably one of my main influences would be Ray Brown. It's just that hard groovin' big sound, just make it swing kind of thing.

MR: So you live in Los Angeles now?

KK: San Diego.

MR: Oh you're still in San Diego.

KK: Yeah.

MR: And what do you do to promote yourself?

KK: Everything. You do everything you can and have it cost as little as possible. I have a mailing list that at one point when I started in San Diego I just, every gig I played if somebody was interested I'd put them on a mailing list. I'd make up these post cards, had somebody from the music department take some black & whites of me all around campus with my bass and so I'd make these post cards and take them to Kinko's and send out a monthly mailer and this is where I'm gonna be. At a point, it cost you two hundred bucks, you'd get enough people between the postage, bulk mail, and by the time you get the labels on it and you sort your zip codes and — so now I'm pretty much just doing an E-mail list, and I did a festival in Washington state and these high school kids just went nuts. And so a couple of these kids E-mailed me, because they were at one of my clinics. And I give my E-mail info number, if they want to call for questions or if they're looking for a tune or they just want to say hey. That's part of this music is the passing along as much as we can as we learn it. So these kids E-mailed me and said we want to set up the official, unofficial Kristen Korb web page. So I now have a web page. So that helps. And I do the E-mail list and just talking with people and making phone calls and just being there, being out as much as I can and meeting people.

MR: What's a typical week like for an aspiring jazz artist these days? I mean do you do other things besides playing jazz?

KK: Yeah, well it's all music related so that's cool. The gigging pays my bills, whether it's on the road, playing local gigs in San Diego and those kinds of things. That pays my bills. But then I teach a couple of classes at a community college, I do a jazz history class and a vocal jazz ensemble and that pays my taxes. And then I teach some private students and that gives me money to put gas in the car and food on the table. But yeah the weeks vary a lot between the classes. Because Monday is usually a big teaching day for me. And I'm also taking French this semester so that's kind of kicking my rear end a little bit. But that's Monday, Wednesdays from eight to ten thirty, and then I start teaching with vocal jazz kids because I do an extra hour with the rhythm section from three to four and then vocal jazz is four to five thirty and then I teach the jazz history from seven to ten on Monday nights. And then Tuesdays are like my big teaching day so I do private lessons in the afternoons there. Wednesday is just the vocal jazz in the afternoon, and then gigs and practicing you know whenever, wherever, usually a couple — average about two hours of business calls a day keeping in touch with people and sending out packages as they need to be sent.

MR: What's the jazz scene like in San Diego these days?

KK: It's undergoing some transition right now. A year ago I mean there just was, everybody was working. It was really great. And since this millennium thing, New Year's Eve kind of fizzled for a lot of people. I think they didn't sell as many tickets for things. I had work but it was one of those things where a lot of people didn't. Or they thought they had gigs and then they got canceled at the last minute. But I think because people paid so much money for these events that it really put a lot of clubs in a hard place and so a lot of them aren't hiring as much, or they're minimizing the size of the groups. But I love the San Diego jazz community because they are so supportive. It's a wonderful place to get your chops together. Because you've got older musicians, you have younger musicians, and the older ones are patient enough with the young ones coming up that they'll say hey, no, you need to get out of *The Real Book*, you're just going to start learning tunes this way. Or this is what you need to do. When I'm playing a ballad I want your bass lines to be like this. So it's a really good place to be nurtured without the fear of losing your gig. Because I think sometimes, like the times I've been up to L.A., nobody really wants to let you in. It's like hey, all right, you're a bass player, cool. But they don't really say hey why don't you come check out this, or come to this session, or why don't you come to this club and sit in with us. Where in San Diego it's very welcoming. Very supportive. In our little community of bass players we're always calling each other, hey man I've got this gig but I'm double booked, would you take this gig. Or we're always referring somebody for things. It's a very giving, encouraging community there. And I really like that.

MR: I think you play the right instrument, as far as getting work. At least from my area, there's a very short lists of bassists.

KK: That's one of the appeals of the instrument for me. But I love it anyway, even if it wasn't. There's no way I could be a brass player. My lips were never meant to do that. They weren't. With the Music Ed degree, they made you play a little bit of everything, and it was one of those situations where we're all in this little semi-circle and everybody's playing and making these nice sounds and here I am, and they're like "blow, Kristen, blow," and I'm like — I could never do it. I just realized at that point that I picked the right instrument for me.

MR: How do you go about learning all the tunes required to get you through a weekend like this?

KK: There is no cramming for this exam. You cannot do that. Actually a year ago it was one of those situations where I realized I was really lacking. I would be able to sing tunes, but to remember the changes and stuff, I was just kicking my rear end. So I made a goal that I was going to learn five tunes a week. And so just pick an album, pick a CD and you just start going through it. And then I have a piano player in San Diego, Pamela York, who is

really great, and she and I get together every week and beat up on each other. Okay I'm going to learn these songs, well I'm going to learn these. Okay. So then we challenge each other and we'll say "Stella By Starlight" up a major third every chorus. But you know Ray Brown told me, I had a lesson with him, and I did this song, he wrote this tune "Benny," and I did a lyric to it. And I was ready for this lesson with him a year ago. I went in and I'm just like I'm going to just swing the snot out of this thing. [sings]. You know just a nice medium groove, and I was feeling good I was like yeah, I'm doing it. It's in E flat. And I'm feeling good about it. He's just sitting there. "Now do it in B." And I was good for about the first four bars until it started going in their weird cycles and I just went crash and burn. And he says "you see what you've got to do now?" He says "do them in every key." It's got to be like turning the wheel. You can't have a formula like only the one chord to this, the four chord to that. You've got to hear it. You've got to be able to sing your bass lines and hear those changes so you can sing them. And that way you never know what situation you're going to be in or who you're going to be playing with, and you've got to be able to just turn the wheel. It doesn't matter what key it's in. You've got to be able to just turn the wheel and go. And so I started learning tunes. And boy, if you take a song that you're struggling with and can't remember the changes, and all of a sudden you start putting it in other keys, you will learn it very fast and you'll own it. But I play a lot with recordings. Not just for the changes but for the intensity and I mean just practicing bass lines by yourself can be kind of a drag. But I'll listen and I'll transcribe bass solos, bass lines. Paul Chambers right now, I'm working on "Oleo" because I want to really improve my rhythm changes. I feel like I'm not being as creative with them as I'd like to be walking-wise. So I'm transcribing a chorus a day. Nothing too huge but just taking it in bit by bit so that way I can start assimilating it into my playing. That to me is the best way to learn tunes. To listen, to work with the recordings, and then to play it with other people and take it through some different paces. And then after that it's a matter of just time, letting it settle and letting yourself grow with it and get to know it even better, and just using your ears a lot too. I've learned a few songs this weekend.

MR: I'll bet. I like watching the bassist and the piano player. Sometimes they'll like look at each other and you raise your eyes like, but what did that say to the piano player, back and forth.

KK: Sometimes what it is, is that even if you both know the song, because jazz is such a wonderfully creative thing, a lot of times people have alternative changes for different sections. Turnarounds — do you do two-five-one, do you just go five-one, do you take it up a half step. Sometimes that's what the eyebrow means. I'm going to go up from where you think I'm going to go. So it's very cool. And that to me is one of the exciting things because it's such a conversation. You have to listen to everybody in order to be in the

conversation. Listen to where they're going and watch and the eye contact, and letting them know you're just digging the groove or nice solo.

MR: How did your CD with Ray come about?

KK: That lesson with Ray. Out of that, yeah. I just said this is what I want to do. And I wasn't asking him to help me necessarily, I just wanted to know am I good enough, and if so, who do I need to talk to. Because education is a real strong part of my family. I come from a family of teachers — not music-wise necessarily — but a lot of elementary school teachers and administrators and I know that teaching is a part of who I am. And I enjoy passing along the information. But I want to play. And at the same time if things aren't happening and being lucrative at the time, I'm going to go and put all my energy into what I know I can do. So I wanted to get going with the performance thing. Otherwise if I started teaching I was afraid that I was going to be all teaching and then I would let the playing go. And Ray had told me at that lesson, he wrote his address, and bring me a demo tape, you know, send me this tape. Well I brought one back that night to his concert. He said you're pretty fast with that, aren't you? It's like well I'm not going to waste any time. And I was just so stoked to get the lesson. That was all I wanted. I just wanted to learn and just to be part of that and when he grabbed my bass from me and started playing things and I'm singing over the top and my head is just racing it's like he used to do that with Ella Fitzgerald, oh my gosh, oh my gosh. You know. And then I was making tacos a couple of weeks later, making dinner and my phone rings and I answer it. "Is that Kristen?" "Yeah." "Have I got a surprise for you." I'm like, "Who is this?" "Ray Brown." I just about dropped the tacos. And he said, "You know that tape you sent me?" I said, "Well, yes sir." "That was a bad tape you know." "Well I'm young, I was a student, it was a school concert, but I'm getting better all the time." "They liked you anyway."

MR: Oh did he say that?

KK: Oh yeah. Oh yeah. And I'm like, "Who liked me anyway?" I didn't know he was going to take it to a record company. I had no clue. And he had talked to Telarc. And he said "you got an audition." So I did my audition for Telarc and he happened to be playing in Chicago at the Blackstone, Joe Segal's room, the Jazz Showcase. And so he flew me out to do one night. And basically I sang two tunes and the record company people were there and I was scared half to death. I was just shaking. And it went all right. And he actually asked me to stay an extra night. He said they don't need to know. He said I want you one more night. So I got to stay the second night. It was worlds better. And it was one of those things where it was just so exciting for me to be a part of that. And through that audition on the gig we put the CD together. And Ray took care of everything. We talked about the tunes, but basically I just showed up and he had everything arranged.

You know, Plas Johnson, Conte Candoli, Oscar Castro-Neves. It was just awesome. And I think out of that whole thing one of my favorite moments was when Ray, he came down to San Diego to my house, and we're sitting at the piano going through some tunes and ideas, and we were going to do "A Train." And he says well my ex-wife used to do stuff — my ex-wife used to take things, you know, and she'd take it slow and then she would make it fast. And so he says well let's try this with "A Train." Because I don't think anybody's done it. Well we're sitting there together on the piano bench and he's playing some chords and it's just like by the time we got done with doing it slow, we just looked at each other and it was like that's it. That's what we'll do. We don't need to take it fast. And it was just that moment of creating with him, in such a casual situation. But it was, for me it was just so unbelievable. It was very cool.

MR: The percentage of gigs that you get called for these days, are they mostly for your singing or your bass or for both? Now people can get two for one I guess.

KK: Yeah. Well it's interesting. Because like locally they didn't even know I sang. Because the other musicians said, "Oh we've got to see you with Ray Brown, oh that's so great, man I bet those bass duos are just cool." It's well actually I'm singing on the album. "You sing? We didn't know you sang." I play. I'm a bassist who happens to sing. So then once that was established that I actually did sing as well, then people were like "Kristen we want you to play bass, we need a bass player on this gig. Since you're coming on the gig could you bring your sound system? We'll let you sing a couple of tunes too." And here I am, you know there's five guys in the band and here I am lugging the eighty pound mixer box and the JBL speakers. Or I'll get a call, like I'm going to be doing this festival in Banff in a couple of weeks. And so I'll be doing bass clinics, improvisation clinics, and then I'll sing with the big band. So it's crazy. Or I'll work vocal jazz festivals but I'm there as a bassist. So I'll be working with choirs or with rhythm sections, but primarily my focus is to get the rhythm section together. And I'll do rhythm section clinics and then that night of the concert I'm the bass player. I don't sing. Or sometimes at the instrumental ones I'll play bass to support — I was in Twin Falls, Idaho in February. And I worked with big bands and stuff like that during the day. And then at night I was the bass player for Bobby Shew and Frank Mantooth was on the gig and then a great drummer out of San Diego, Duncan Moore was on it as well. So I was the bass player but then on one of the sets the next night I sang with the big band and then I picked up my bass and played in a combo setting. So it's really fun because it's always something different.

MR: Yeah, and from a career standpoint it's good too.

KK: Oh yeah.

MR: You've got different ways you can go, you can do both or you can do one or the other.

KK: I love it.

MR: That's great.

KK: It's wonderful. And like if I get sick, I can still just play. You know with a singer, you know it's just so flaky because if you've got a cold or if the air is dry you can't sing. But this, I can always play.

MR: Ten years from now if we sat down and did this again, what could you hope to be telling me?

KK: I want to play with the jazz greats. I mean this is certainly doing that. I want to do more. I want to do a lot more.

MR: Who's on your wish list to play with?

KK: Kenny Barron, Russell Malone and Jeff Hamilton are my top three right now. That's my goal in the next three to five years. Actually one to three years. I want to play with those guys. I want to be in those bands. And then beyond that, you know, of course, everyone — I think I would really like to be in New York. I'm feeling this urge to be there. I've just got to figure out how to get myself there. Because one of the things — that I've been taking care of my own business, I know that the scene there is marvelous. Every time I visit I have a blast. I learn so much, it's just a creative bubble bath.

MR: Yeah, there's an energy there for sure.

KK: Oh yeah. I learn so much. But at the same time I don't want to move into that community and have to be dependent on it for my livelihood. Because I know that it's not going to pay in that way. You'd have to get out of town and I don't want to move there not really knowing too many people. So what I'm trying to do right now is make visits at least once a year. I'd like to up it to twice a year, and just hang for a week or more each time, and meet the musicians. I was there a year ago and I got lessons with Ron Carter and Rufus Reid, hung out at Milt Hinton's house one afternoon. Russell Malone is really cool. I mean he took me to a bunch of jam sessions and we got a chance to do some playing, so it was very cool in that I started meeting more people. So I see that continuing, and to be able to do more of these jazz parties and play with these guys. And I want to play with the greats before they go. These guys are going way too fast. I think they have something because — I have a lot of respect for the younger players but there is something so intangible about the guys that went through the stuff like what Ray's gone through. And the guys that played with Monk or played with Ellington, Blakey, the guys that have been through the history. There's just something in their music that does not exist in the younger players.

MR: I know. I wish I could put it in words, what that is.

KK: I think it's a spirit. It's a real spirit thing. And I just want to be a part of that. And I think the only way you can be a part of that is if you're there. You hang with that, you live with

them, you live with that music. To play with it is a totally different vibe than to sit in the audience and to listen to it. Just playing with these guys is such an eye-opener for me. These guys that I've been listening to on recordings, but to actually get to be a part of that creative process with them, you really end up taking a lot with you. I think Kenny Barron embodies a lot of that. I think he's got that — he has his own voice in the music. But at the same time there's all this tradition within him and he just swings so hard. But he can be abstract with some ideas but at the same time you always know he's got a foot in that tradition, no matter how far out he goes. I think Russell Malone has got a lot of that as well. And Jeff Hamilton of course from all of his years with Ray, really just has that feel. He just purrs. His time is so good. And I was at the west coast jazz party with him two years ago and just to have him just growling at me over that ride cymbal, you know, I mean there just is nothing that feels like that.

MR: You were born with a groove. I have to say that.

KK: Oh thank you.

MR: You know, just the pleasure that that obviously gives you, which is actually undefinable but when it's right, man, and how one person can really provide it more than another. I mean what exactly is that person doing that's so much better than everybody else?

KK: I don't think it has anything to do with technique. I really, the more I'm looking at it, I mean there's a certain, I mean if you want to be really analytical about it, you know, I mean you listen to somebody like Ray Brown, I mean he's got these big, fat, the round tone, everything is connected, there's attack, but Jeff Hamilton calls it the growl. You've got that growl inside that's just — I've done this with students. They get playing and they — it's the difference between going from note to note to note, to seeing things in a line. And I find that when I'm growling, that comes out more. And you just have to love a groove. I mean how many people get excited about quarter notes? I do. I love quarter notes. And I can play a gig and never take a solo and I'm just fine with that. But just a good groove, and just be able to support everybody else and make a horn player smile because they love what you played behind them, or playing a kick off what the drums or the piano was doing. I mean that just sends me. It's such a thrill. And I got a lot of that from Ray. But I don't know, there are some guys that have just the most amazing technique in the world but it won't move your soul. And there are some guys that are just so sloppy with the technique that you're just amazed they can even play like they do. But there is something within. I think it's that spirit. If you want to call it the growl or whatever, I think there's something in there. But I mean that's the beauty of jazz too is that everybody has got such an individual voice. You can have the same technique as five other guys and everybody's going to have something different to say.

MR: I kind of enjoy the fact that it's intangible, because that's what makes the greats. If it wasn't intangible, then we'd all be on the same level I guess.

KK: Well and I think some of that intangibility is the voice. It's really being true. I mean we take in everything. I mean Ray is certainly — I mean Monk used to call him Slam Pettiford.

MR: Oh, okay.

KK: Slam Stewart and Oscar Pettiford. And Ray has told me stories about going to watch Oscar Pettiford play and just being the wide-eyed kid in the front row. And we take in everything that we hear. I mean I'm sure there's a good bit of Barbara Mandrell and Anne Murray and Tom T. Hall inside of me. You know? I mean just because that's part of my upbringing. It's part of what I know. But I think ultimately our job as musicians is to tell our story in whatever way that is. And that's an intangible. Because everybody is so unique and beautiful in their own way. Everybody has something to say. And to have it intangible, we're not trying to be anybody else but ourselves. And I think that's one thing that the masters really have. When you think of Thelonious Monk, for good, bad or otherwise, Monk was always Monk, whether it was profitable for him or not. He played his way in his terms. And that wasn't necessarily everybody's bag. Because sometimes he wasn't always a team player from what I understand. But I wouldn't have Monk any other way. That was him. You listen to that ride cymbal of Art Blakey and you know it's Blakey. That's his story. Mingus. He was always Mingus whether it was profitable or not. You know from about two quarter notes what Ray Brown's sound is. It's so cool.

MR: That was such a big part of that era of the music is people having their own identifiable sound.

KK: And I think today's guys, I mean everybody's got their own sound. Even though we've got a lot of kind of clone people. But I think if you listen to them long enough I think at this point we've listened to those guys so long now that it seems more obvious to us. Where with a lot of these younger guys we still haven't listened to them enough. Because I'm getting to the point now where I can hear Russell in about three notes. But I've been doing a lot of listening. I want to play with him so I'm listening to his music. I'm playing his tunes. And after a while you hear that voice come out in whatever way that that is. But I've had friends tease me for a long time because I couldn't tell saxophone players apart. Man I couldn't tell a tenor from an alto, I was just pathetic. And then I really started listening to them and playing with the CDs. And all of a sudden it's just like hearing the voice of a friend. But it's a matter of that listening. And I think with the younger guys we just haven't done that enough. But we can certainly hear the influences. You know I listen to Dianne Reeves who is a marvelous singer. I mean her pitch is just pristine, her breath support is just amazing, and she certainly has her own sound. She is

being very eclectic with her music, you know, borrowing from pop, borrowing from jazz. She's doing a little bit of world music kinds of things. Very creative. But man every once in a while I will hear a Sarah Vaughan lick come out of her, it's just you know, some of those half step [scats] kinds of things. I just go — that was a Sarah Vaughan thing. But she's still Dianne. When Ray plays "Swing Until The Girls Come Home," that's Oscar Pettiford, but it's still Ray.

MR: That's great. Well I've really enjoyed talking to you.

KK: Oh I've had a blast.

MR: I wish you the best and I hope you keep your calluses up.

KK: Oh I have to.

MR: What's the process of finding your next record, your next CD?

KK: Well I was supposed to do something for Azika and the week I was supposed to go in the studio the distributor went bankrupt and so I mean I had my gigs all subbed out, I had everything ready to go. And that came up and postponed everything. So at this point I have tunes, I have arrangements ready, and it's just a matter of getting it financially put together. So I don't know if Azika at this point is getting ready to do something. They told me I'm their next project. And I know they have a new distributor but it just takes time to get the money going again. So hopefully that will work out soon. Otherwise I've got a couple of people that sound like they're interested in finding investors for me and making something happen. But I am certainly feeling the need to get in and do something. I think that's a part of the process of this music as well, not just the live performance but having the recordings to kind of mark your growth. And there's a certain amount of marketability thing that you know you have to have a new CD every so often so people have something to hear. But for me personally I feel the need to mark my progress. And there's not a more concrete way to do it. I mean even when I was a kid about every six months I would make a little tape, these are the songs I'm working on, this is where I'm at, and I still have them. I don't know if the cassettes will play anymore, but it's one of those things that just to mark your progress so that, you know, on some days if you're feeling really bad about your playing you go back and listen to a few years ago and go oh, man, I'm really a lot better. Or some days when you get feeling cocky, you go back and you listen to those and you go oh, that's where I came from. You know? It keeps you honest. And I think it's important for us to see how we're growing and having those markers I think is a good way to do that. For me I feel that's something I need to do.

MR: Well best of luck to you, and I'll kind of look for you in New York in the future too.

KK: Oh I would love that.

MR: We're fairly close to there and hope it goes well.

555 KK: Thank you.

556 MR: All right.

557 KK: Appreciate it.